

Zulu war dance
Zulu warriors in full battle dress, armed with cowhide shields, stabbing spears, and knobkerries, perform a war dance (*umghubha*). Ceremonial dancing and singing, performed before and after battle, was of great religious significance to the Zulu. Note the plumes of dust in the photograph, caused by the vigorous stamping of unshod feet.

Yet military life for the Zulu warrior was far from idyllic. Fights were constantly breaking out between individuals or rival regiments, who attacked one another with knobkerries (heavy sticks). These punishing duels were connived at by the officers (*izinduna*), who saw fighting as a useful toughening exercise for the warriors, although combat with spears was strictly forbidden. The food supplied to the regiments by the chief was often meagre, at times a serious cause of discontent. Warriors were generally forbidden to marry, a regulation that became more irksome as men grew older. In practice, marriage was permitted after around 15 years of service. Warriors were released from their military duties at around the age of 40.



Cowhide shield
Shields needed to be both strong and lightweight. The distinctive colouring of the shield showed the regiment to which the warrior belonged, and his status within it.

ZULU WARRIOR SHIELD

FIGHTING METHOD

A Zulu warrior functioned as part of a mobile aggressive army dedicated to locating and then destroying an enemy force at close quarters. One of Shaka's reforms was to abandon the wearing of sandals, because he believed his warriors could move faster unshod. Thus the Zulu travelled barefoot – a European observer described the soles of their feet as hardened "like the hoof of a cow". Warriors advanced in columns at around 30km (20 miles) a day, often accompanied by boys under 12 years old carrying their cooking pots, sleeping mats, and extra weapons. On occasion, cattle were brought along as a mobile food supply, but when maximum speed was required the warriors travelled light and survived by foraging. Scouts reported back on the enemy's location and strength, and acted as skirmishers, screening the movement of the army.

Although the Zulu always exploited speed of movement and knowledge of the country, they were in no sense guerrilla fighters. Their aim was to engage the enemy in pitched battle, deploying thousands of men at a time in a decisive attack. Before entering combat, a warrior would carry out various rituals, including anointing himself with a magic potion to guarantee his safety. With his regiment he would then take up his appointed position in the traditional "buffalo horn" battlefield formation. Younger regiments formed the "horns" on each flank, which were to encircle the enemy. The centre, or "chest", would be composed of experienced fighters, since it was expected to bear the brunt of the battle on a frontal charge. The "loins", a body of older veterans, was held in reserve.

Movement on the battlefield was directed by the *izinduna* using hand movements or messengers, although Zulu armies rarely departed from standard tactics with which all were familiar. The warriors would advance towards their enemy at a steady jog, sometimes beating their shields rhythmically with their spears. Once within suitable distance, they rushed forward in a last full-tilt dash, launching their throwing spears when about 30m (100ft) from the enemy. At close quarters the stabbing spear and shield were put to deadly use. The Zulu never took prisoners, massacring their enemy to the last man and ripping open the bodies of the dead to release their spirits.

EFFECT OF FIREARMS

The Zulu first experienced the power of European firearms when fighting Dutch-speaking Afrikaner settlers, known as the Boers. At Blood River in 1838, the firepower of a few hundred Boers defeated a Zulu army possibly numbering 10,000 men. Zulu leaders subsequently obtained firearms for their warriors, but failed to make any radical change in tactics. They continued to practise massed infantry assault, which against rifle-armed troops in a prepared position was bound to cost them heavy casualties. The Zulu did learn to make good use of cover in approaching the enemy position and attacked in

> "WE WILL GO AND EAT UP THE WHITE MAN AND FINISH THEM OFF. THEY ARE NOT GOING TO TAKE YOU WHILE WE ARE HERE. THEY MUST TAKE US FIRST."
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> **ZULU ARMY**, ADDRESSING KING CETSHWAYO AT THE BATTLE OF ULUNDI, 1879